

MONEY, MURDER AND CONSPIRACY

The graft allegation against a Congress minister and the charge of political killing by PDP have rocked the coalition Government

■ By Aijaz Hussain

The resignation of one of his senior ministers, Peerzada Mohammad Sayeed, from the Cabinet as well as party presidentship on graft allegations could not have come at a worse time for Chief Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad who has declared a war on corruption in the state. It only adds to fears arising out of a multitude of separatist forces forging unity among themselves at a time when the state is scheduled to go for elections.

Sayeed was forced to quit after young independent legislator Shoab Lone disclosed on the floor of the Assembly recently that the state education minister, who was also the president of the state unit of the Congress party, had accepted a bribe of Rs 40,000 from him for getting a job done. This was for the first time in the state's legislative history that a member accused a minister of taking bribe. If that was not enough, Lone went on to make another stunning revelation that his father and People's Democratic Party (PDP) minister Dr Ghulam Nabi Lone was not killed by militants, as the state Government inquiry had reported, but had become the victim of political conspiracy in 2005. "My father was not assassinated by militants but he fell victim to a political conspiracy as PDP was on the verge of a spilt," Lone said in the Assembly. "My father was not in favour of the party's policies and programmes."

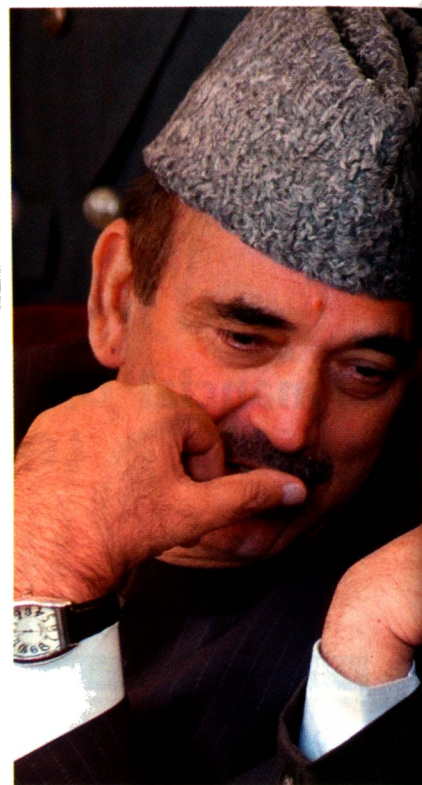
The PDP leader was killed in a brazen daylight raid by "militants"



who scaled the wall of his residence in a highly guarded enclave of central Srinagar just days after a devastating earthquake struck the region in October 2005. Along with the senior Lone, one of the two attackers, two police officers and a civilian were also killed and seven others were wounded in the ensuing gun-battle. The other attacker managed to escape after a three-hour standoff. The Government inquiry later said the killings were the outcome of a "security lapse".

The dramatic developments in the House proved ammunition for the Opposition, particularly the National Conference (NC), and forced Azad to order a probe into Lone's killing by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI). An alleged threatening phone call to Lone's mother contributed to the Bollywood-style thriller that unfolded in-

The twin charges levelled by Lone may expose all the three mainstream parties in the state—Congress PDP and NC.



LONE BATTLE: Shoab Lone (left); Chief Minister Azad (above left) with Peerzada Mohammad Sayeed

side the Assembly. Before he revealed Sayeed's name, a phone call was allegedly made from the cell phone of one of the minister's drivers to the Lone widow which threatened her to restrain her son from revealing the minister's name. The chief minister ordered the arrest of driver Altaf Noorani but Shoab Lone alleged that the calls were made by the minister's wife, Dr Tabassum. Police later registered a case against her. The corruption case is being handed over to the state Vigilance Department.

The developments expose all the three major mainstream parties in the state—cracks in the PDP, chinks in the Congress and political opportunism of NC. It now becomes clear that the very foundation of the coalition Government is political exigency rather than the purported coalition programme.

From the point of realpolitik, Sayeed's resignation makes the Congress and the chief minister look upright. The move takes away a lot of